



◀ Etched in stone

This Aztec Sun Stone (c. 1500), measuring 12 ft (3.7m) across, found at Tenochtitlan, capital of the Aztec Empire, depicts a history of the cosmos and its eras, or suns. The central face is likely the sun god, Tonatiuh, with his tongue a symbolic sacrificial blade.

Counting the days

The calendar system related to ritual was called the *tonalpohualli*, meaning “the count of days.” It formed a 260-day cycle, with subsections ruled by various gods, and divinatory uses including the casting of horoscopes. This cycle consisted of 20 periods, each 13 days long. Each day in the calendar had a number (1–13) combined with one of 20 “day” signs that included a lizard, a flint, or rain: so a day might be identified as “1-Rain” or “13-Lizard.” Each combination recurred once every 260 days. Lucky or unlucky days, based on the characteristics of the associated number, day sign, and god, were considered vital for all kinds of things, from planting crops to making offerings to the gods. A person’s day of birth could also be used to predict their fate. Days with 13 in the name were thought to be favorable due to links with the 13 principal Aztec gods, while a 1-Wind or 1-Rain birth day might be associated with turning into various types of dangerous sorcerer and casting spells.

Symbols of the 20 calendrical day signs

As with many philosophers and magic practitioners of the European Renaissance, the Aztecs placed great importance on astrology and astronomy. Close observations of the skies and precise time-marking fed into a complex calendar system of interlocking cycles, including a 20-sign zodiac, that was central to magic and ritual.



Divine tools

Aztec culture was filled with magic practitioners, including *teixcuepani* (illusionists), *temacpalitotique* (sorcerer–thieves), *tlacatecoltl* (sorcerers known as “owl men”), *ticitl* (physician–diviners), and *tonalpouhqui* (soothsayers). Many objects were invested with special or divinatory powers, such as maize kernels, which were cast on the ground to form meaningful patterns. Rods might also be cast to determine which god was responsible for an illness.

◀ Casting maize

Overlooked by the wind god, here a diviner casts maize kernels onto a cloth to read their patterns, as shown in the 16th-century *Codex Magliabechiano*. Maize divination could also involve casting the kernels into water.